sparsely populated. The high altitude and harshness of terrain served to isolate it not just from India to the south, but also China to the east and Mongolia to its north. The devastating hordes of Mongols that poured through Central Asia and reduced the Russians and half of Europe to vassalage never entered Tibet, even though it lay at their very doorstep. Even when they attacked India, they chose to bypass Tibet and entered the subcontinent through the easier passes of Afghanistan.

The frontiers were also ill-defined because governmental control in Tibet (and China) remained fairly fluid. Given that both the Chinese and the British were constantly probing and pushing their frontiers forward (the British staying away from the political boundary of Tibet but confining themselves to the tribal belts that acted as a buffer between Tibet and Assam), it was perhaps inevitable that there would be serious differences in opinion between the two once China invaded and annexed Tibet. Later, China would, ironically, on behalf of Tibet, lay claim to areas that the Tibetans themselves had conceded as not being a part of political Tibet.

The only comprehensive attempt at defining the frontier between India and Tibet in a scientific manner was when British and Tibetan officials met in Simla in 1914 to demarcate the boundaries. The third party at the convention—the Chinese—was present to simultaneously demarcate the boundaries between inner and outer Tibet. This convention was later mired in controversy as both the British and the Chinese adopted different stands at different times (as we will see when we deal with the Simla Convention in the next chapter).

Over the last one hundred years since the three parties put their heads together, the Indo-Tibet border has seen many changes as empires fell and new political dispositions came up. To understand the huge, rugged, disputed expanse that runs across the entire width of northern and eastern India, the frontier needs to be broken up into three different regions—the western, the central, and the eastern. Between the central and the eastern section lie the three erstwhile Himalayan kingdoms of Nepal, Sikkim and Bhutan.

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